PRODUCT DELIVERY

Roadmapping and Strategy Execution

How a Now-Next-Later roadmap translates strategy into action without promising more certainty than exists, and why roadmaps should be built on outcomes.

What a roadmap is for

A roadmap exists to translate a product strategy into something a team and its stakeholders can actually act on, without pretending to know more about the future than anyone really does. The tension a roadmap has to manage is that stakeholders often want certainty and fixed dates, while product work is inherently uncertain the further out you look.

Now, Next, Later

The Now-Next-Later format, popularised by Janna Bastow, resolves this by grouping initiatives into three horizons instead of a fixed timeline. Now covers what the team is actively working on, with a reasonably high degree of confidence about scope and outcome. Next covers what is coming after that, defined clearly enough to prepare for but still open to change. Later covers ideas and directions being considered, deliberately kept loose since committing to details this far out usually turns out to be wasted effort once reality intervenes. This structure protects a team from overpromising while still giving stakeholders visibility into direction.

Roadmaps built on outcomes

A strong roadmap is organised around outcomes and business intent rather than a list of features and ship dates. Each item on the roadmap should be traceable back to why it matters: which part of the product vision or which measurable goal it serves. This keeps the roadmap useful as a communication tool with leadership, since it lets a Product Owner talk about strategic intent and expected impact rather than defending a fixed list of promised deliverables. A roadmap built this way also stays easier to update: when priorities shift, it is the initiatives inside each horizon that move, not the underlying story of where the product is heading.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/product-ownership/roadmapping-and-strategy-execution

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